

A cyberattack disrupts vehicles fitted with anti-drunk driving systems, leaving hundreds unable to operate

Intoxalock, a US-based company, manufactures ignition interlock devices, breathalyzer systems installed in vehicles to prevent drunk driving. These devices are typically mandated for DUI offenders. To remain functional and legally compliant, the devices require a mandatory calibration at authorized service centers every 25 to 30 days. If this maintenance is missed, the system automatically locks the vehicle as a safety precaution.

On March 14, 2026, Intoxalock suffered a Distributed Denial-of-Service (DDoS) attack. Attackers flooded the company's servers with massive amounts of traffic, causing a complete system shutdown. Because the system was down, hundreds of drivers who were due for their routine calibration could not complete it, resulting in their vehicles being remotely locked. For example, in Connecticut alone, 7% to 10% of the company's 6,000 active users were directly impacted and lost mobility.

The company paused some systems as a precaution, then granted 10-day extensions, set up dedicated support channels, and covered direct costs. Services were restored on March 19.

Questions:

1. The interlock device requires periodic calibration. How did the attack exploit this dependency to amplify the impact?
2. The Intoxalock devices themselves are not directly internet-facing, but their calibration process depends entirely on the company's backend servers. In a DDoS attack, those servers became unreachable. For safety-critical IoT systems that require periodic online validation, how would you architect resilience against DDoS attacks?
3. What possible motivations could attackers have for launching a DDoS attack against an ignition interlock company, given no data breach or ransom was publicly reported? How does this differ from ransomware motives?